

Seven Marks of a False Teacher

Scripture gives believers the tools to identify deception. The following seven marks are drawn from patterns found throughout the New Testament. They are not an exhaustive, infallible checklist; they are a rule of thumb, a practical framework for discernment. No single mark in isolation necessarily condemns a person, and some faithful teachers may trigger a flag in one area while being sound in all others. But when multiple marks appear together in a sustained pattern, the warning signs should not be ignored. Jesus said: “Ye shall know them by their fruits...” —Matt 7:16. These seven marks are the fruit to look for.

1. **Examine their source of authority.** A faithful teacher submits to Scripture as the final authority. They teach what the text says—verse by verse, book by book. The Word drives the teaching. A false teacher uses Scripture as a springboard for their own ideas or bypasses it in favor of experience—a dream, a personal revelation, a “God told me”—treated as an authority that Scripture must bend to. When someone claims ongoing, extra-biblical revelation that functions as a parallel authority alongside or above Scripture, they have left the foundation the apostles laid (Eph 2:20). The test: does the man serve the text, or does the text serve the man?
2. **Examine their gospel.** A faithful teacher holds to salvation by grace alone through faith alone in Christ alone—nothing added, nothing subtracted. A false teacher adds to the gospel or takes from it. Some add works, sacraments, speaking in tongues, tithing, or submission to a specific leader as conditions of salvation. Others subtract from it—removing the reality of sin, eliminating the existence of Hell, or denying the exclusivity of Christ. Paul drew the line as sharply as it can be drawn: “...If any man preach any other gospel unto you than that ye have received, let him be accursed” —Gal 1:9. The test: is anything added to or subtracted from faith alone in Christ alone?
3. **Examine their fruit over time.** A faithful teacher demonstrates consistent character across years and decades, not perfection, but a sustained pattern of integrity. A false teacher shows a gap between public profession and private conduct. They preach sexual purity while living in secret sin. They preach generosity while hoarding wealth. They preach humility while building personal empires. Jesus said: “...every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit” —Matt 7:17. The test: does the fruit match the profession over time, not a single snapshot but a sustained pattern?
4. **Examine their accountability.** A faithful teacher is accountable to a local church, a body of elders, or a structure that can correct, rebuke, and if necessary remove them. A false teacher resists accountability. They build governance structures that protect them from oversight. They surround themselves with loyalists who will not challenge them. When the man is the ministry and cannot be questioned, the conditions for abuse are already in place. The test: can this person be corrected or removed by someone with authority over them? “Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch for your souls, as they that must give account...” —Heb 13:17.
5. **Follow the money.** A faithful teacher does not build personal wealth on the backs of their congregation. A false teacher consistently monetizes the ministry—branded products, luxury lifestyles, private jets, mansions, and salaries hidden from the people who fund them. They teach that financial giving to their ministry guarantees financial blessing from God—a transactional gospel that exploits the poor and the desperate. Paul warned: “...

they that will be rich fall into temptation and a snare [trap], and into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition [utter ruin]” — 1 Tim 6:9. The test: is the teacher getting rich from the ministry?

6. Watch how they respond to correction. A faithful teacher receives criticism, examines it against Scripture, and adjusts where needed. A false teacher attacks the critic. They label discernment as a “religious spirit.” They weaponize “touch not God’s anointed” to deflect legitimate biblical scrutiny. They accuse those who question them of lacking faith or being divisive. Proverbs draws the distinction plainly: “...rebuke a wise man, and he will love thee” — Prov 9:8. The test: when corrected, does the person examine themselves or attack the corrector?

7. Examine what they produce. A faithful teacher produces disciples who know their Bibles—people who can open the Word, read it, understand it, and apply it to their lives. A false teacher produces followers who know the teacher. The congregation can quote the pastor’s books but cannot find Habakkuk. They know the latest sermon series but cannot articulate the gospel. They are loyal to a personality, not to Christ. The test: do the people under this teacher’s ministry know the Word of God, or do they know the teacher?

The men who bear these marks come in the three kinds described in Chapter 12, false prophets, false teachers, and worthless shepherds, and the marks are the same for all three.

Every one of these individuals will stand before God and give an account for everything they have said and done, especially what they have said and done in His name. Jesus issued a devastating warning: “Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven... Many will say to me in that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name? and in thy name have cast out devils? and in thy name done many wonderful works? And then will I profess unto them, I never knew you: depart from me, ye that work iniquity [wickedness]” — Matt 7:21–23. They used His name. They performed in His name. And He will say He never knew them. James warned: “My brethren, be not many masters [teachers], knowing that we shall receive the greater condemnation [stricter judgment]” — Jas 3:1. The stricter judgment is coming. And no platform, no following, no book deal, and no amount of applause will shield them from it.